



has managed to hold on to its young striking talent, Parthib Gogoi, who contributed nine goals. With a trophy under its belt, Benali believes that the club is on the right path and will channel the added pressure to focus on achieving its goals this season.

Chennaiyin FC had a proactive summer transfer window, wrapping up most of its deals by June. Now the pressure is on Owen Coyle to get the best out of the Indian core and improve on last season's sixth-place finish. Forwards Kiyan Nassiri and Gurkirat Singh's moves to Chennaiyin will be closely watched to see if they can get regular starting roles.

In what could likely be Sunil Chhetri's final season of professional football, Bengaluru FC has brought in Jose Pereyra Diaz, Alberto Noguera, and Rahul Bheke, all from Mumbai City. The club will be hoping that striker Sivasakthi Narayanan can get back on track after a disappointing campaign last year. While winning the League Shield may be out of reach, the 40-year-old

Chhetri will want to have a crack at silverware through the playoffs.

The loss of charismatic coach Ivan Vukomanovic and Jeakson, combined with an underwhelming pre-season, may have dampened expectations for Kerala Blasters fans this season. The additions of Noah Sadoui and Jesus Jimenez bring some value to the squad, but the weakened domestic core could make it difficult for them to challenge for a playoff spot.

Khalid Jamil, the only Indian coach in the ISL, kept Jamshedpur FC firmly in the playoff hunt until a five-match winless run towards the end of the regular season scuppered its chances. Jeremy Monzorro's departure will likely hurt the club, but a refreshed foreign core, including Javi Hernandez, Javi Siverio, Jordan Murray, Stephen Eze, and Lazar Cirkovic, should keep JFC in the thick of things.

Uncertainties remain

Punjab FC will do well to offset the loss of Talal, Jordan Gill, and former

Test of the best: Chennaiyin FC had a proactive summer transfer window, roping in forwards like Kiyan Nassiri (25) and Gurkirat Singh. It remains to be seen whether they will get regular starting roles. PTI

head coach Staikos Vergetis and still compete for the playoffs as it did last season.

New entrant Mohammedan SC will add more history and rivalry to the competition with Kolkata giants Bagan and East Bengal. However, the club lost its top scorer, Lalhiansanga, to East Bengal and will bank on its overseas signings to guide it to a respectable campaign.

Hyderabad FC's participation was confirmed earlier this month after BC Jindal Group completed a takeover, resolving the financial issues that snowballed from bad to worse under its previous ownership. However, head coach Thangboi Singto will find it hard to rally a lacklustre squad to improve on its bottom-of-the-table finish from last season.